

Degrees in C

On the staff, each note in a major or harmonic minor scale has both a name and a Roman numeral. Here are the C major and C harmonic minor scales. Each note up the scale is identified with its Roman numeral and degree of the scale.

The image shows two musical staves. The top staff is for the C major scale, and the bottom staff is for the C harmonic minor scale. Each staff has nine notes, each with a Roman numeral and a degree name below it.

Scale	Degree	Name	Note
C major	I	Tonic	C
	II	Supertonic	D
	III	Mediant	E
	IV	Subdominant	F
	V	Dominant	G
	VI	Submediant	A
	VII	Leading note	B
	I	Tonic	C
C harmonic minor	I	Tonic	C
	II	Supertonic	D
	III	Mediant	E $\flat$
	IV	Subdominant	F
	V	Dominant	G
	VI	Submediant	A $\flat$
	VII	Leading note	B
	I	Tonic	C

LOOKING CLOSER

The seventh note

In most scales, the seventh note of the scale is only a half step below the tonic at the top of the scale, and is called the leading note. However, when the seventh note is a whole step below the tonic, it is called the subtonic.

A musical staff showing the interval between the seventh note (B) and the tonic (C). A purple arc connects the two notes, with an arrow pointing to it labeled "half step". Below the staff, the notes are labeled "VII Leading note" and "I Tonic".

◁ Leading note

In major and harmonic minor scales, the seventh note is just a half note below the tonic. Because it leads the melody toward the tonic, it is called the leading note.

▽ Subtonic

In natural minor scales, the seventh note is a whole step below the tonic. In this case, the note is called a subtonic. Here the subtonic is shown as part of the C natural minor scale.

A musical staff showing the interval between the seventh note (B $\flat$) and the tonic (C) in the C natural minor scale. A purple arc connects the two notes, with an arrow pointing to it labeled "whole step". Below the staff, the notes are labeled "I", "II", "III", "IV", "V", "VI", "VII Subtonic", and "I Tonic".